

A GIFT OF FIRE THIRD EDITION - SARA BAASE

CHAPTER 2: PRIVACY

Lecture 2

"Big Brother is Watching You"

Syada Tasmia Alvi
Lecturer, Dept.of CSE
Daffodil International University

"BIG BROTHER IS WATCHING YOU"



Databases:

- Government agencies
 - Collect many types of information
 - Ask business to report about consumers
 - Buy personal information from sellers
- Main publicized reason: data mining and computer matching to fight terrorism
- Private information can be used to:
 - Arrest people
 - Jail people
 - Seize assets

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❏ Databases:

- Millions of crime suspects are searched in government databases
- Shift from presumption of innocence to presumption of guilt
- Computer software characterizes suspects
 - Innocent people are sometimes subject to embarrassing searches and expensive investigations and to arrest and jail.

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Small Sampling of Government Databases with Personal Information

❑ What data does the government have about you?

- Tax records
- Medical records
- Marriage and divorce records
- Property ownership
- Welfare records
- School records
- Motor vehicle records
- Voter registration records
- Books checked out of public libraries
- People with permits to carry firearms
- Applications for government grant and loan programs
- Professional and trade licenses
- Bankruptcy records
- Arrest records

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- ❑ Some constitution articles (laws) protect privacy.
- ❑ Modern surveillance techniques are redefining expectation of privacy.
- ❑ In some countries:
 - No court order or court oversight needed to get one's private information.
 - 2003-2005 report found "widespread and serious misuse" of the FBI's (**Federal Bureau of Investigation**) national security letter authorities.

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Two key problems arise from new technologies:

- ❑ Much of our personal information is no longer safe in our homes; it resides in huge databases outside our control.
- ❑ New technologies allow the government to search our homes without entering them and search our persons from a distance without our knowledge

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Video Surveillance:

- ❑ Security cameras in Shopping centers, malls, banks, etc.
- ❑ Cameras alone raise some privacy issues.
- ❑ When being combined with face recognition systems, they raise more privacy issues.
 - Increased security
 - Decreased privacy

Thank You